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Digital

Passion

Fuelling the pursuit of technology knowledge

Lead Feature

What Lies Beneath

To many, gaming is an addiction, an obsession. Is a gamer a social outcast, or just plain misunderstood? Just what is inside the mind of a gamer?

Suprotip Ghosh

As we enter the dimly-lit gallery at Hiranandani, in the distant Mumbai suburb of Powai, a huge poster of a female model greets us. Seductively, she calls the faithful Underground to satiate a *Need for Speed*.

Elsewhere, speakers pour out heavy metal. Arclights on pedestals focus on wall hangings, and there are PCs strewn around. To the uninitiated, this seems chaotic. But once the lights and sounds become familiar, a pattern emerges.

"These PCs are for *Unreal Tournament*, those for *Counter-Strike*, and the ones here, *NFS*," someone in a World Cyber Games T-shirt points out. The computers face each other, making eye-contact between opponents impossible. Once you sit and strap in, your opponent is a cyborg, or a football team, or a few cars. Unreal. Positively Unreal!

The team playing *Counter-Strike* looks tense, typing in familiar codes and keystrokes. Terse commands make the rounds, as does the occasional whoop or cry on making a kill, or getting killed. It is real, very real: the emotions, the adrenaline, the arclights above, the huge banner of *Counter-Strike* with the first character—female—looking intently just over your shoulder.

The Passion

Psychiatrist Dr Mukul Choksi tells a story: his friend had brought in his teenage daughter.

